names for India. Indian diplomats, possibly from the Gupta Empire, appeared in Chinese courts in the fifth and sixth centuries. [31] Buddhism also spread to China from India. During the Han period, two Indian monks, Kasyapa Matanga and Dharmaratna, travelled to Luoyang in today's Henan province carrying Buddhist texts and icons. [32] Other Indian monks such as Kumarajiva, Paramartha, and Bodhidharma also journeyed to China in the fifth and sixth centuries. This diffusion of Buddhism from India to China was not seamless: some ideas struggled with translation ('dharma' was translated by the Chinese as 'fa', suggesting a more rigid law or code) while other Buddhists concepts (e.g. renunciation) were seen to contradict Confucian notions of filial piety. [33]

These early contacts paved the way for further Chinese visitors to India. The most detailed surviving early Chinese account of India is by Faxian, who travelled in the early fifth century via Dunhuang and the Pamirs to the Indus and returned from Bengal to China by sea. Faxian provided detailed geographical and cultural descriptions of India to Chinese audiences for the first time. [34] Similarly, motivated by religious education, Chinese translators such an Xuanzang visited the capital of king Harsha in Kannauj (in present day Uttar Pradesh) and Nalanda (in today's Bihar) in the seventh century. Later, while based in Chang'an (today's Xi'an), Xuanzang was able to maintain correspondence through travellers with his Indian teachers. Drawing upon Xuanzang, the geographer Daoxuan argued that India—not China—should be considered the geographical centre of the world. Other Chinese travellers to India included the diplomat Wang Xuance who journeyed via Tibet and whose disastrous mission assumed some kind of military dimension, most likely an armed intervention in a local civil conflict. [35]

Trade between India and East Asia accelerated after the tenth century, with improvements in seafaring technologies in India, China, and Southeast Asia. Trade routes linked southern China with Sumatra and Java, Malacca to Sri Lanka and the Malabar coast, and Gujarat to Hormuz and Baghdad. Traders and merchants who were Tamil, Sumatran, Chinese, and Muslims of various ethnicities all participated in these exchanges. The